The Andrew Poems

By Shelly Wagner

(Pg 10-11) When I told the police I couldn't find you,
they began a search that included everything,
even the boxes in the house.
They made me raise every lid.
I told them you would never stay in a box,
not with all the commotion.
You would have jumped out,
found your flashlight
and wanted to join the search.
Poor Thomas, leading men
who didn't know us
through neighbors' garages
where you never played,
hoping they were right
and we were wrong
and he would find you
and snatch you home by the hand
so the police cars would
get out of our driveway
and the divers would
get out of our river . . .
That's not what happened.

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INTRODUCTION

It was the nightmare every parent fears. On a summer Virginia evening, Shelly Jones Wagner was pushing her five-year-old son in a tire swing in the backyard, idling away the hours between dinner and bedtime. She left him only for a moment, but when she returned Andrew had disappeared. He was found later that night, drowned in the river behind their home.

Shelly began writing to help her cope with the intense feelings of grief and loss. Her words were ultimately published in The Andrew Poems, a book of narrative poetry that has comforted and inspired thousands of parents and other determined survivors.

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(Pg 12-13) Near midnight,
your grandfather came into your room
where Thomas and I had waited.
He said you had been found
and they needed something to cover you,
not for the cold – it was summer,
not for your comfort – too late;
but to wrap the small, wet body
as with a shroud.
I grabbed your bedspread,
gave it to your grandfather.
He left your room
carrying your white spread
draped in his arms
like a child.

I'd rather remember you
wet from your bath.
After you wiggled into your pajamas
you would climb on the hamper

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to see yourself in the mirror,
comb your wet hair straight back
and ask if that made you look famous?
With affirmations,
I would carry my legend to his room.

Had I gone outside that night,
no one would have let me bathe you,
wash the mud from your cheeks . . .
You could not come back to your room.
But I wonder,
did the river sweep your wet hair straight back
and make you famous?

(Pg 36) A simple question,
Never a problem before.
"Do you have any children?"
Really a simple question.
Easy. I Say, "Yes," but
What do I say to "How many?"

"Two," my hard-headed
Heart always says.
One is dead.
Must I say only one?
Absolutely not – I have two
Sons.

[Memories of] Mice . . . **(Pg 5-6)**
A life parallel
behind our refrigerator --

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a mother raising her two baby mice.
Her children played where they shouldn't.
Thomas, my nine-year-old man-
of-the house, set the trap with cheese.
Three-year-old Andrew wandered in
as we lay the loaded trap on the floor;
I perched him on the kitchen counter
with the impossible command,
"Do not move."
Thomas and I armed ourselves
with a mop and a broom
and jumped up on the ledge with Andrew.

The babies sashayed down the alley
between the refrigerator and cabinet.
Like children on a jungle gym,
they climbed over the locking bar,
Slipped across the spring,
ate the orange cheese.
When they heard us laughing
the mice jumped off,
too small to trip the trap,
too young to know the danger.

Andrew went to his room,
returned with his toys.
He parked two Matchbox cars
in front of the refrigerator,
set up a tiny picnic table

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with two chairs and an umbrella,

then set the table with cheese.

And Television **(Pg 14-15)**

He watched "The Young and the Restless."at lunch,

eating peanut butter and jelly

with his grandmother

and "The Price is Right

was his favorite.

If I wanted him

to come in from the yard

all I had to do was call,

"Andrew Minton! Come on down!"

One day, in response to the silly summons,

he leapt into my arms,

clasped my face between his hands,

and planted a huge smooch

right on my lips.

He hopped down explaining,

"That how they do it on the 'Young and the Restless.'"

(Pg 41-42) I remember the funeral director saying,

"We have only two caskets for children.

They are four feet six inches long.

I know which one you will want."

There it was – closed --

in front of the church --

blue, handsome, shiny, cold.

But I had seen the velvet cushions

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at the funeral home --
clean, soft, silver.
We put stuffed animals
and poem all around you --
you lying there in the box
just longer than you.

(Pg 10) *(echo)* I told them you would never stay in a box,
not with all the commotion.

(Pg 15) After everyone was gone
I walked to the river.
Standing there
I looked up at the sky
as one does when addressing the dead,
"Andrew Minton, come on down."

(Pg 17) You drowned on Thursday.
We buried you on Saturday.
Your brother's birthday was Sunday.
Someone brought a cake with twelve candles.
Your brother smiled bravely;
thanked everyone for their gifts,
Including the brightly striped beach chair
with a matching towel.
For a moment Thomas tried
to amuse us.
He wrapped the colored towel
around his shoulders
and sat in his striped chair.

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He was a sight. Some laughed.
But to me it looked like Joseph's coat
of many colors – proof that a son was dead.

(Pg 24 -25) After the death of my child,
I believed it possible
that clothing, toys, rooms,
even shoes
could become shrines.
I carried his little pairs of shoes
full of holes and memories
to the trash.
Hearing the garbage truck coming,
I made myself watch as the contents of the can
were tossed into the truck.
For weeks I had nightmares.
I dreamed of going to the dump
to search for them,
find them and bring them home.
The shoes are gone –

But not all of them.
Andrew, I kept my favorites:
my favorite teddy bear slippers
and your reliable red rubber boots.
Today, the shoes
are lined up in pairs
like left-facing and right-facing griffins
on guard under your mother's bed.

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I wish I had your loafers
with your lucky pennies in them.
You were buried wearing those.
(Pg 26) I put off buying him men's clothing,
but for Easter
he wanted a tie – a red one
and a nav blue blazer.
Now, just under six years old,
he is buried wearing it forever --
as old a man as he will ever be.

(Pg 28) Someone offering comfort said,
"This will pass."
I recoiled like a slapped child,
fearing if the grief were to fade,
I would be left with nothing.

[But] What If? **(Pg 78)**
What if the divers had surfaced empty-handed?
What if someone had found him just sitting in a tree.
He would have been wide-eyed watching the flurry of lights
He would have loved the flashlights of those on the shore
shining in all directions like gleaming swords.
He would never have forgotten
the blue lights on the police cars swirling
like the moonlit wake of the rescue boat.
The boat's searchlights and acrobatic divers
would seem to any child a circus act.
Had he jumped from the tree and come running,
the search would have been no more than a midnight

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cruise,
the black hearse would not have come for his body,
the helicopter pilot could have killed his floodlight,
the media would have abandoned their story,
and his grandmother never learned
from the eleven o'clock news
that her youngest grandson was missing from our yard.
Embracing him, would I have scolded him or covered him
with kisses of sweet relief?

(Pg 15) *(echo)* "That how they do it on the 'Young and the Restless.'"

(Pg 78) Definitely kisses.
probably never would have scolded him again at all.
Would I have let him sleep with me?
He asked to every night at bedtime.
No, that was not his place.
His room was across the hall where I could see him.
But he did drown and he is not in his room anymore.
Since that evening when he did not come when I called:

(Pg 10) *(echo)* "Andrew Minton! Come on down!"

(Pg 78) Since that evening, every night – he is in bed with me.

(Pg 31) I lie down
pull the river up
around my ears . . .
how natural he looked,
how peaceful,
as though he were only sleeping.

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(Pg 36) *(echo)* "Do you have any children?"

Two. I have two sons.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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